

Dying to Prosper the Kingdom

Open to Luke 16 for a minute while we take some facts from here.

Did anybody have a good time Sunday? I did.

Sunday, He spiraled me right into getting into the helps ministry again. We defined helps and governments. The operations came into existence as apostle, prophet, teacher, workings of miracles, gifts of healings, helps, and then governments.

Helps seems to hold priority over governments. We found out the helps ministry appears to be the entrepreneur, the entrepreneurship of the simplicity of giving. It seems to be someone of means who comes alongside and supports the government. I mean the government of the church.

I have always suspected there was a calling like that. A few years ago He began to reveal it. Sunday He had me refresh a little of it, and since Sunday everything concerning the subject has been coming at me, whether through conversations or the news.

I found out that bankruptcy is climbing by thirty-one percent every year. That cannot last much longer. We are spending a dollar ten when we only make a dollar.

One of the most elaborate traps of all is easy for a man to fall into because when it comes to pleasure, there is no man's flesh that does not want in. Even when you love God more than anything that exists, your flesh still says, "I want that. I want that." It will not stop until it is glorified.

When Jesus talked about the sower sowing the Word and what takes the Word of God out of a person's life, stopping it from working and producing a hundredfold, He listed persecution and affliction first.

When adversity comes, a man wants out. "I will take anything to get out of adversity. Whoever will feed me and take care of me, I will listen to what they have to say." That is the way the world is. When persecution and affliction come, the flesh wants out.

When it comes to pleasure, the flesh wants in.

The first levels of takeout were persecution, affliction, and the cares of this world. Nobody likes to carry heavy loads, burdens, and cares. "How am I going to feed my family? How am I going to do this and that?" The cares of this world are a third-level takeout.

The next level is the deceitfulness of riches, the ability to be deceived by riches as a believer who has received the Word.

Finally, the last level is the lust for other things. I call that the God complex. It has to do with self-exaltation and self-glory. I also call it the Elisha complex. It is when a man wants to become a little god. Nothing else satisfies him. He lusts for that kind of power. On the other side of the coin, that

is what makes your Hitlers.

Money, by itself, may not be enough. They lust for that kind of power.

Many men of God survive everything. They survive money. They survive women. Women of God survive men. They survive everything, and then the lust for other things comes. Suddenly they are "Elisha to come."

It would be nice to be a single call on this earth that nobody else has ever called: prophesied about in the Old Testament, and suddenly here you are. That is how it likes to think.

Money is awfully powerful next to the lust for other things when it is not just pleasure a person wants. The power in money can go a long way toward serving that other dream, that power-hungry dream.

These are high-level takeouts. When adversity comes, the flesh wants out. When pleasure comes, the flesh wants in.

We can go to India, Haiti, or any third-world country. They measure the term "third world" by the strength of government, army, and military power. But if you measure by how much people eat, many live below that, on the brink of starvation.

You can go to a country like that and evangelize people. If you hold money or food between you and them--"Hear my message, and I will feed you"--they will listen. And you should feed them. But the problem is that a lot of wrong messages are coming too. Mormons and Jehovah's Witnesses run through those countries. When Russia opened up, the Jehovah's Witness movement became very strong there.

If you hold food between me and what you want to say, I am going to listen for the food. I may have a genuine experience. "I will worship God every day if He will get me out of prison and feed my kids."

Russian students came to America with the full intention of receiving the gospel, being delivered, being trained, and going back. Often, in the natural, it becomes a one-way trip. Who can you blame?

When it comes to loyalty, pleasure will try your loyalty to God much more severely than adversity. Every time.

When Gary was talking and giving me the latest on the revelation God had given him, he said things that made me see things in my life I did not like.

What do we always do when we get a lump sum? Our heart takes us in the direction of what we are. Apple plums dance in our mind. We say, "Oh yes, I have to give God His tithe." To us, that is putting Him first. Even at that, the percentage of the body of Christ that tithes is pathetic. Our scare tactics are failing. They are not tithing anyway.

When it comes to a decision between pleasure and whether I will etch out a little more for some kind of assault on the devil's kingdom, I certainly tend to pad my security and creature-comfort areas.

My mind goes there quickly: "This is coming in. That is coming in. This is paid. That is paid. I am going to get this. I am going to get that." After I sift through that whole line, I finally calculate what is left over.

It is pretty sick.

We certainly want God to put us first. Putting Him first is something that has been working in me. The only reason many of us are still in any kind of grace in these things is that we have been deceived by many teachers before us. We genuinely think we are doing God a favor by squeezing George twice before we drop him in the offering.

The whole thing has been preached the other way. The more I get into it, the more I realize I was genuinely deceived, because most everyone backed righteousness up with the good life:

"He wants you to have the good life."

If I had to choose now between the peace I have and what you would consider the good life, if you asked me to choose between peace and sanctification or a Lexus in the front yard, I would run out and beat that Lexus with a sledgehammer. I would rather have the peace.

When I was deceived about those things, I did not know the difference. When God started to show me how His whole thing worked, the death He put me through was hard because I did not understand it.

I went from being very popular on the circuit, able to raise offerings, to saying no. They would fly me in to raise offerings. I became very popular. Then I said no three or four times, and it spread through the circuit. I was not so popular anymore.

I did not know how to die. I only knew how to hear Him. I had fasted and prayed enough that He was able to say, "I do not like some of this stuff you are doing." So I stopped.

It is rough to stop.

You come over here and get this building with twelve acres: a million-dollar piece of property, maybe a million five by the time interest is done. You have to pay the interest. It is not okay to file bankruptcy just because some lawyer says it is okay not to pay the man.

We moved over here, and suddenly I could not do anything. I could not hand envelopes out. I could not threaten. I could not beg. I could not even go out and raise money for it.

Do you know how hard it is when you are sitting on a gift? My soul was trained. I could manipulate a crowd whether God was helping or not. I had all that sitting there and could have run out and gotten lots of money.

I could not do it. I just sat there and died, believing Him.

I hardly knew what was going on, but I was willing to obey. Now He has taught me enough that I pray I do not get you in trouble before we understand the rest of this.

I knew there were certain things I could not do anymore, so I stepped out to obey Him. Thank God, because of it, I was able to teach some of you as much as I knew. Then God took some of your calls because you are more streamlined in that area than mine. He sends me for the lost, and I teach preachers often. That is my anointing.

But if you are an entrepreneur and you have that ministry, then He is certainly going to take you into the Word by the Holy Spirit and train you for what He has called you to do.

Some are running out now in that helps-entrepreneur line and finding out that much of what we were teaching was backwards. We wanted to keep the increase and give God the percentage.

Now my thinking is being straightened out. He has my attention on the other life instead of this one. My attention is continually on the reward on the other side. When I think in parables, I think of what He is trying to explain and how it affects eternity. You have no idea how many parables that has opened up.

Luke 16:9 says:

And I say unto you, Make to yourselves friends of the mammon of unrighteousness; that, when ye fail, they may receive you into everlasting habitations.

Make friends of the mammon of unrighteousness, using the power that is in money, so that when you fail--when your life on this earth as a steward is over--they may receive you into everlasting habitations.

The day Jesus was talking about is explained in verses 1-8. An unjust steward was terminated and did not know what to do. So he took the authority of his stewardship in the name of his rich man and started canceling people's debts against him.

The rich man was so impressed with the wisdom of this world that he said the children of darkness are wiser in their generation than the children of light. They will take greed and those things that serve them and use them to the nth degree. The unjust steward canceled the debts so they would receive him into their houses later.

Then Jesus switches to you and me.

He says, "If you want to have more wisdom than the child of darkness ever dreamed of having while serving greed, lust, and wealth, make to yourselves friends of the mammon of unrighteousness. Use the power that is in money, so that when you fail and your life on this earth is over, every person whose debt was canceled will receive you into everlasting habitations."

What debt was canceled? The debt the whole human race was put into by the first man, Adam, when we were sold into bondage and slavery to sin.

If you use money to evangelize the lost, if that is where your wisdom is bringing you, if everything in you solicits the mammon of unrighteousness to serve the canceling of the sin debt of the world against God, then His promise to you is this: you will have more wisdom than the man wielding worldly wisdom and greed for his purposes, because God's purpose is much higher.

If you truly make it to that place in your transformation, mortification, and dying, then the treasures of the ages and the wisdom of God are available to you to cancel people's debts.

On the day you walk into heaven, people will stand there and say, "I was lost. That last seven million you wrote for Japan is where I was saved. I heard you were coming in today. I heard your departure was at hand. Several million of us are at the gate. We want you to know that even though you did not preach the message, you were there. Because you had so much wisdom, you incorporated partnership with Jesus Christ and paid for the entire revival. Our debts were canceled, and we are here to watch you go to your reward."

If you do not think that is available, there are positions in Him we know very little about. Few have attained to them, but that does not make them any less available.

Some of the books God is sending into the land, such as the series Rick Joyner is doing, are blatant warnings against the church and its carnality. People keep telling me, "I can only read about one chapter at a time. Then I have to stop and die awhile."

It is a rough book because it exposes greed and deception.

Yet we have the hidden treasures. He calls Himself Wisdom. Wisdom visits. The ministry He has to you right now can just about only be wisdom.

That ministry is available to you here and now. God does not cut off His face to spite His nose. If He could pour out millions through people, He would. Do you think He lets one person on a remote island go to hell because nobody had money to evangelize him?

Have you noticed that first-world countries have very little revival? Our revival is conditional. Some people go to a third-world country and have miracles. Then they come back to America and almost have nothing.

I have had one foot in Ensenada, Mexico, and one foot in San Diego, with a prayer line on each arm. The San Diego arm was lucky to get a headache healed. But the Ensenada arm below Tijuana had miracle after miracle.

People always say, "They have all the faith in the world."

The truth is, they really do not. If they had all the faith in the world, they would have been healed before you got there. What they are is little babies eating off your tree, totally unaccountable for everything.

When you get to America, you cannot go through one toll station without paying. If you stood in a toll station for a week and asked everyone coming through, "Who is Jesus?" do you think you would find one who did not know?

"Explain a little about Him."

"He is the Son of God."

"What did He come into the world for?"

"He died for our sins."

"Are you living for Him? Do you believe?"

"Oh yes, I am a Christian."

From that point on, many will go no further. Some will say they do not believe certain things, but most have heard enough to harden themselves.

What happens in America is accountability.

Benny Hinn has what I would call a first-world anointing. What most people boast of in the third world, he has in the first world. You should see him in the third world. I understand in India, in the same area where I ministered and with the same people who helped him, someone had a growth this big just fall off. You could not believe the miracles that took place.

That was in Benny's life because he mortified, died, and went on to receive what I classify as a first-world anointing. A third-world anointing works over there, but when you get here it wanes. Why? Because of the level of accountability of the people.

Most people here have been stopped somewhere by the deceitfulness of riches. New York alone has enough money to make the present missionary effort in the world look like Tinker Toys. Believers included, we are sitting on it.

We will go so far in the mortification process, but when it starts costing us something, that is it. We are not going further. That is where most of the ceiling sits over the body of Christ in America.

We do not mind going into debt, spending ourselves to a dollar ten on the dollar to increase our comforts, and filing bankruptcy at an increase of thirty-one percent every year. Somebody ends up holding the bill. The rates increase on the rest of us to pay for those failures.

What is doing that? Who and what will stop it?

In a third-world country, you do not have much anyway. You do not know where your next meal is coming from. It is easier to sell out.

But in America, you can work selling hamburgers, get a car, put in a little overtime, and pay your own way. People would kill to come here.

At first, when someone comes, he is excited because all he wants is training. Then his loyalty is put on trial: death to creature comforts. Pleasure is a fourth-level takeout. It tests loyalty.

The strange thing is that loyalty is not usually put on trial by lump sums. God knows you will not do much with those. You feel good about a tithe and a small offering. But you could not stand under pressure when you wanted to give twenty or thirty cents of the dollar in your pocket.

That dollar was put under systematic pressure: creature comfort, creature comfort, creature comfort. "I have a right. This is America. I need two cars."

Everything is set up for that lifestyle. You cannot move into a city, get a single dwelling, a car, and exist in this society without it demanding a certain standard.

God wants us to prosper, but I can tell you right now: when the kingdom of God is last in anything you do, you will suffer in the end.

These messages Gary has been preaching are the first time I saw wisdom in giving God more than I keep, and how to get started in it. Usually, under conviction, we jump out emotionally and give half our paycheck. Then we are no further along than before, and at the end of the month our check is short.

God has to do something with our motives.

He will answer this prayer as fast as any prayer I know, when you take time to prepare yourself for it:

"God, I want to spend more time with You."

People say, "I just do not have time to spend with God."

What they are really saying is, "It takes every moment I have to maintain the lifestyle I have."

They have farmed their wife out for minimum wage and done everything else, and it is still hard to support the fourth bedroom, the stereo system, the extra TV, and everything else.

They come to me and say, "I just do not have time to spend with God." They should not say that more than three times, because we will sit down with a pencil.

If you pray earnestly, "God, I want to spend more time with You," and you really mean it, then there must be corresponding action. I do not care what it costs me; I want to spend more time with Him. If I do not have action that corresponds with my big mouth, then it is not abundance of the heart speaking. Someone can teach you confession, but the rest of the time you run around talking out of your heart.

What you need to do is learn how to talk all the time. If anything in your heart wants to bust out and say wrong things, tell it to shut up. Bridle the tongue until the heart is turned.

God will do anything for you, but if I say, "I want to spend more time with Him," then I must be willing to do what corresponds with that prayer. I will drive my cars another few years. I will get a chainsaw and saw half the house off for half the budget. Whatever I have to do, I will start seeking Him and His wisdom and spend the time I said I wanted to spend with Him.

When I add another bedroom, it will be after I gave Him His, on my climb, being faithful with what I have.

I remember the days when I could ask Him for something and it would come in days later. Then there was a period when it would not happen. Now it is coming back strong. I remember those days as a child in God. I would almost say it, and He would run out and do something for me.

I slept in the halls where I preached. If the fire marshal caught me during the first three months of ministry, I had to go sit in my car. Sometimes I would preach and the offering would be ten, twelve, or fourteen dollars, and inside I knew I had to take it all home. In a four-day meeting at ten or twelve dollars a night, I might have to take that home, and the hall was five dollars a night.

I remember the first time someone walked back into the kitchen where I hid my clothes and my bed and said, "I just felt to give you this hundred." I could not remember rejoicing like that.

I walked out of my job into that. I would walk to meetings if I had to. I did not care.

Then the airplanes started coming. I began hobnobbing with prosperity. "This is your rights," until pretty soon I wanted the land. You eat a great big sandwich of the good life, then you want another and another, until pretty soon what God gives you for ministry, you consume for self, saying, "I have a right to this."

No. I want to find out.

Luke 16 says:

Make to yourselves friends of the mammon of unrighteousness; that, when ye fail, they may receive you into everlasting habitations.

The next verse says:

He that is faithful in that which is least is faithful also in much: and he that is unjust in the least is unjust also in much.

Most of us dream about believing for a big lump sum. "When that big lump sum comes, I am going to give God His."

Whether He knows you will or not depends on what you are doing with the little you have. What you do with little determines what you will do with much. Little flesh appetite becomes big flesh appetite. All you have to do is turn it loose.

People say, "God is so good to me," while looking at a Corvette, a Dodge Ram, a house on an estate, television cameras, and everything else. "I am a child of the King. Look at me." Pretty soon you have to invent things to send out in the mail to keep your servants.

But with what Gary is preaching, when that big fat three-million-dollar check comes, all you have to do is look at what he taught, and you will know what is God's and what is yours. Do not think you will suddenly go before God and get a three-million-dollar raise that year.

"My needs have suddenly increased."

Wait until next month and see what you get from God, you consuming flesh thing.

If I am faithful in little, I am faithful in much. But who ever heard of teaching stewardship where you get this much and God gets that much, and then He starts bringing increase and you still get the same while He gets all the increase? Then it goes on for six more months, and now it is six times what you ever made, and you still get the same while He gets all the increase.

That is not how they taught us. They taught us that we keep ninety percent and He gets ten. That is why they are always running out and begging.

Pretty soon, your ten percent will be five times more than your ninety used to be. The question is whether you will have the wisdom to be faithful in little so He knows you will be faithful in much.

God has tried to get this over to people before, but they ended up in cults because someone said, "Sell your houses, sell everything you have, and bring it to my feet."

People are scared of this kind of thing. That is why I said the teaching Gary brought forward is the most balanced thing I have heard on this.

Can you imagine a year from now having more, with the raises you went before God and asked for in provision, saying:

"God, the way everything is going, I used to give You ten percent, and then I told You I would keep this provision. Right now it may be eighty percent or seventy percent of what I make, but I can certainly get by on the provision I need. I can pay my bills, have enough to run around, fellowship a little, take the preacher out once in a while, buy him a coat, and treat him nicely on his birthday."

Then pretty soon that thirty percent you are giving to God turns into what the seventy percent used to be. Statistically, now you are giving seventy percent when you figure where you came from and how much it is in proportion to what you used to give.

Now you are giving more than you keep, and it is causing such activity you can hardly keep up. You need a bigger house or other provision. So you go before Him and say, "God, I am going to take an increase of this much, and the rest is Yours again."

Pretty soon you have much more than you did when you were greedy, and you are working a reward with it besides.

Some people are content with little because all they want to do is pray. They have a car, a pot of beans, and their whole life is given to prayer. God will bless that.

Why will He bless it? Let us go to Matthew and look.

I have never seen anything like what Gary is on. You could not make me leave this service if you pried me out with a crowbar. I have wanted to know this for a long time.

People are afraid because cults say, "Sell all you have and bring it to my feet. Move into a commune." That is not scriptural. But His blessings are scriptural. You are called to walk before Him.

Go to Matthew 19:22:

But when the young man heard that saying, he went away sorrowful: for he had great possessions.

Jesus had told him:

If thou wilt be perfect, go and sell that thou hast, and give to the poor, and thou shalt have treasure in heaven: and come and follow me.

That is extreme for a question. But when the young man heard it, he went away sorrowful because he had great possessions.

Then Jesus used it as a teaching opportunity:

Verily I say unto you, That a rich man shall hardly enter into the kingdom of heaven.
And again I say unto you, It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle, than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of God.

The eye of the needle was the security inner gate of the main gate in Jerusalem. It was shaped like a camel's back. If a camel loaded with treasure and trade goods came through, they had to make the camel get down on its knees, take all the stuff off it, and make it walk through.

Jesus was creating imagery: camels with their wealth removed have less trouble going through the eye of the needle than rich men have entering the kingdom of heaven.

This rich man had a good heart. He said, "I have kept all these things from my youth up." Jesus said, "There is one thing you did not keep. You did not love your neighbor as yourself, because if you had, you could give this away and follow Me. You cannot do it, can you?"

The disciples were exceedingly amazed and said, "Who then can be saved?"

Jesus beheld them and loved them in their dilemma:

With men this is impossible; but with God all things are possible.

Then Peter said:

Behold, we have forsaken all, and followed thee; what shall we have therefore?

Peter asked the question most of you are too spiritual to ask: "What do we get?"

Jesus said:

Verily I say unto you, That ye which have followed me, in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of his glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel.

That is good for them. How about us?

Verse 29:

And every one that hath forsaken houses, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my name's sake, shall receive an hundredfold, and shall inherit everlasting life.

But many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first.

That last verse is difficult. It jammed up all the parables for me for a long time.

Mark 10 explains it more thoroughly:

There is no man that hath left house, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my sake, and the gospel's,

But he shall receive an hundredfold now in this time, houses, and brethren, and sisters, and mothers, and children, and lands, with persecutions; and in the world to come eternal life.

Jesus spiritualized it. You are not going to inherit a hundred wives, so forget it. He left wives out of the hundredfold list.

This means that as a steward I am going to manage resources that can inherit all that: houses, brethren, sisters, mothers, children, lands, and nations. If I have forsaken all to follow Him, then whatever provision I ask Him for, He will give it to me.

The strangest thing happens when I am dying enough to receive what I thought I wanted. The things that were so important a few years ago start losing their interest. I want the ability to be a need-meeting machine. I want enough money in my pocket to straighten somebody out right there, and enough money to go straighten out a nation over there.

He knows it is His because it has been the pound for a long time. However much He increases the pound, He knows it is His. If it was His at fifty thousand when I needed a new car, He knows it is His at five billion.

Imagine your reward from inheriting houses, lands, millions of mothers, brothers, sisters, fathers, and one wife.

Then Jesus suddenly says:

But many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first.

In Mark He did not give a parable to cover that. In Matthew He did.

Did He change the subject when He went into that parable? Of course not. He said the first will be last and the last will be first, then He goes into Matthew 20:

For the kingdom of heaven is like unto a man that is an householder...

He is giving a parable. A parable is something I can understand with my natural mind that illustrates a spiritual application. This spiritual application is about the first being last and the last being first. That statement was attached to Peter's question: "What do we get?"

Jesus answered with houses, lands, hundredfold, and eternal life for the man who forsakes everything, then said the first will be last and the last will be first.

I used to preach that the first were Abraham, Moses, Noah, and Jonah. They heard the gospel first, but had to wait for Jesus to come, while we came later and received the covenant at once. That preaches pretty well, but it does not explain enough.

The first will be last and the last first means this: the man who makes himself first comes in last. The man who makes himself last, the servant--the one who left houses, lands, everything, and asked what he would receive--comes in first.

Those who serve themselves come in last. Those who make themselves servants and slaves come in first.

Jesus says that for those who attend to themselves last in this world, the things that prepare them for the next will pour in by the measures of a hundredfold. And once you catch this, you will not be treated shabbily while you are here.

Prosperity is going to turn. The ones who serve greed and themselves are going to be the ones hurting, and you are going to be the ones all right. It is a cause for great revival.

When I reason things out in teaching, I lose some of you because you do not know where I am reasoning from.

Someone says, "Maybe I need to move to Hawaii."

No. Did you know there were seven tornadoes on the ground at once, heading this way? I do not know if you remember six or seven months ago when I started crying out about that. I saw seven tornadoes and the path they took, how wide it was. It was the most devastating thing.

He told me at that time, through wisdom, to begin to prepare because those things are going to come among the tares. You live among tares, because He is not going to root them out.

There are two ways God handles things. He will give you blatant miracles and take care of you. He will send things to you because you are in the provision. You gave yourself to Him. You made yourself the servant.

In a first-world country, where greed can be so strong, if you manage the process of mortification and become a servant, God likes that.

I saw that destruction in my spirit. Those pictures of Oklahoma City were familiar to me. They think somewhere between fifteen hundred and two thousand houses were destroyed. That thing cut a swath a mile wide. They said it was a level five, which is one percent of all tornadoes. If you had a flat cement foundation, it could tear the pipes out. There is no closet you can get into.

When I first heard six were dead, I knew inside it was going to climb to fifty.

I told you that Y2K does not bother me. I am not bothered by any of it. If I were you, I would watch the changing weather patterns.

"I will get ready for tornadoes."

It does not matter what part of the country you live in: earthquakes, volcanoes, tidal waves. Move to Hawaii, and something will find you. A meteorite can hit the ocean. You cannot get high enough.

But none of those things matters when you separate the pound from the provision and become the servant.

Peter sold out everything. What does he get? Jesus says, "You become My servant, and you come in first. All the lands and houses are yours. You have My provision. You have a reward in eternal life that you cannot fathom. You get My protection. You get everything."

If nobody can get food, everyone around you will eat, and they will get saved. Just ask Him.

These things will come with more frequency, and the strength of them will be in numbers they have never numbered before. That is all right. I am going to do exactly what He tells me. You do exactly what He tells you.

Meanwhile, I would find out what He wants with the rest of my life. You can become an unfathomable, unimaginable servant to the kingdom. In two years, if the Lord tarries, you can end up with more than you have now: more freedom, better equipment for the kingdom of God, and five times more for the kingdom's sake, producing mothers, brothers, and inheriting lands full of people.

I want to inherit Japan.

Give me Japan.

Listen to me, strong man. I am coming at you with fastings, prayer, and a pocket full of money. I am coming after you. As long as they are in an economic situation where they want my money, they are going to hear what I have to say with it.

What we have lacked is the message to go with the money. When people did not have the message, the devil gave them the money. We have to bring the two together.

I believe you can rewrite some history books. I believe you can be a standard-setter. I believe people are going to beat your door down to find out how you can prosper in times like these.

You have to follow Him. You have to start when the devil pulls the dollar out of your pocket and puts it on trial.

My suggestion is to get those tapes. Study them thoroughly. Do not just listen and walk away. Decide what is provision and what is pound.

Your pound may not be very much. The pounds were divided according to ability. It may not be much, but protect it. Protect it like the end of your life and reward.

The first time someone hands you a thousand dollars, ask: provision has already been made, so how do I use this money? Pound or provision?

It hurts. Do you want that alive in you?

We could use a lot of carpets here. We could jack the building up. But that is secondary to holding food in front of people so they can hear a deliverance gospel.

The windows of heaven are opening. Hang on.

Did Jesus change the subject? No, sir, He did not.

At the end of Matthew 19, He says:

But many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first.

Then in Matthew 20:16 He says:

So the last shall be first, and the first last: for many be called, but few chosen.

Now He tags another thought with it: many are called, but few are chosen.

The standard for being chosen is right there in that verse. If you make yourself the servant, if you make yourself last, you come in first. If you make yourself first and exalt yourself, you come in last. The standard by which He chooses you is whether you become the servant.

Then comes the parable. Some men worked from the third to the twelfth hour, and some only worked one hour, yet they all got paid the same. Somehow that is supposed to explain things.

Does it? Yes. But we will get to that.

Can you imagine that? These men worked eleven hours, and another man worked one, and the householder gave them the same.

I used to skip that parable and go to the good stuff because it scared me.

Would you stand up and worship God for a song?